

Chapter 119 - Demigod

Ning Fuyi looked into her eyes. Not only was she not intimidated, but she leaned closer: "How will you not forgive me?"

Chu Qingqiu's red lips parted, but for a moment she couldn't speak. She turned her finger to summon the white bone, pointing it at Ning Fuyi's shoulder to push her away: "You can very well try."

"How would I dare? What if you cut off my hands and feet and imprison me on Purple Mist Peak¹? Wouldn't I be finished?" Ning Fuyi grasped her white bone and removed it from her shoulder.

"I'm not you," Chu Qingqiu said, too lazy to argue with her further. She turned to leave, but was pulled back by someone tugging at her sleeve.

Ning Fuyi raised her other hand in a three-finger gesture and said seriously: "I, Ning Fuyi, swear that all talk of promiscuity is lies, and claims of taking both men and women are even more absurd."

Seeing her speak earnestly, the stuffiness in Chu Qingqiu's heart finally dissipated somewhat. She put her hands behind her back and looked at her: "Oh, so you only like women then?"

"Not so. I like neither men nor women - I only like flowers," Ning Fuyi curved her lips.

Chu Qingqiu's heart jumped. She quickly pulled her sleeve from Ning Fuyi's grasp, her ears burning hot, and strode away.

"By the way, Divine Venerable, do you remember when you were a little flower, you loved to act spoiled and throw tantrums? You were so adorable... Divine Venerable?"

Ning Fuyi watched her embarrassed figure disappear through the door crack, then withdrew her chin and laughed heartily.

Perhaps unaccustomed to love, or perhaps still mindful of that curse, Chu Qingqiu was not even half as affectionate toward her as when she was Su Mo. But Ning Fuyi was already content with this.

In the future, she would work harder to love her more, to help her find the freedom of being human again.

Although Chu Qingqiu seemed so powerful that she didn't need to be loved, when Ning Fuyi imagined the years she had endured alone, she always felt the world owed her too much.

She must have had moments of collapse and fear too. Ning Fuyi raised her hand and brushed away a fallen flower petal that had gotten caught in her collar.

Ning Fuyi entered the room just as Jiuying put down her brush, placing the green feather back in her bosom, and looked up: "Yun Ke² says Jiang Li is not at Penglai, and Penglai hasn't heard any news about Jiang Li either."

"As for that Black Scales, she seems to have received some mission recently. She hasn't appeared since the Demon Slaying Conference," she said, habitually crossing her arms. "From this, it seems Jiang Li might really be in her hands."

"But if Black Scales really is the snake woman, then Jiang Li shouldn't be in danger, right?" Jiuying speculated.

Ning Fuyi shook her head: "Hard to say. The Black Scales I've seen has no demonic aura and is completely unfamiliar with Jiang Li. She's probably lost her memories long ago."

"Besides the Yi Chan Sea³, are there any other places in Penglai where people could be hidden?" Ning Fuyi suddenly asked.

Jiuying replied: "None that we know of."

"Perhaps we should look for that snake woman?" Chu Qingqiu, who had been silent, spoke up, her fingertips tapping lightly on the table.

So half an incense stick's time later, the iron-faced Jiang Wuying, leaning on her dragon-headed walking stick, stood before them. Her hands trembling, she pulled out a yellowed map from her storage pouch and handed it to Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi took it and looked, surprised for a moment: "Xuanyuan Kingdom⁴?"

Jiang Wuying gripped her dragon-headed walking stick with both hands and snorted coldly: "When this matter was first discovered, I sent people to investigate that woman's background. She was just a lowly demon! You were discussing things - why are you suddenly concerned about this dead demon woman?"

"We just think it might be related to this matter," Ning Fuyi smiled as she put away the map.

"Thank you for your hospitality, Senior. We've found some clues and must now set out to find Jiang Li, so we won't say lengthy farewells."

"So soon?" Jiang Wuying raised her eyebrows. "Do you need me to send more people to assist you?"

"No need, Senior. Please just stay at Wu Mountain and await my news," Chu Qingqiu bowed to her and led the group away.

Watching the tall woman's figure disappear behind the courtyard wall, Jiang Wuying stroked her walking stick in silence for a moment, then suddenly called: "Dang Gui!"

Dang Gui walked in from the courtyard and bowed: "Family Head."

"Write a letter and send it to Sect Leader Tang," Jiang Wuying instructed.

Ning Fuyi didn't delay and immediately set out, following the map toward Xuanyuan Kingdom.

Bai Lin⁵ flew gently and steadily, not like Jiuying who would constantly roll and spiral in the clouds, so everyone felt much more comfortable and could settle down to rest and gather strength.

Jiuying had flown all night and was now sleeping soundly in her small qilin form. Qiu Yi sat far away, also resting with her eyes closed. Ning Fuyi sat with one leg drawn up, leaning against Bai Lin's curled tail, carefully studying the map.

The fur beneath her softened, and Ning Fuyi looked up to see Chu Qingqiu sitting sideways across from her, letting her feet dangle like last time, her robes fluttering in the wind.

"Do you know what kind of place Xuanyuan Kingdom is?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

Ning Fuyi shook her head lightly.

"Xuanyuan Kingdom is an ancient country that existed tens of thousands of years ago. It was the dwelling place of the snake demon clan. Originally, they lived in relative peace, but later, due to the conflict between gods and demons, the demon clans gradually declined. The kingdom was eventually buried in wind and sand, its territory becoming a desert. The people either migrated or died, and it disappeared from history."

"The snake demons of Xuanyuan Kingdom weren't ordinary snake demons. In ancient times, they were worshipped by the ancestors and were once placed on divine altars. But later, this worship of snake demons was erased by time, and no one remembered these things."

"If that snake woman really is a descendant of Xuanyuan Kingdom, then her strength being as formidable as Jiuying said is normal. Such a person being used by Penglai poses an extreme threat," Chu Qingqiu said.

Ning Fuyi folded the map: "So that's how it is. If we can eliminate it this time, it would be very beneficial for the future."

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her and said nothing.

"What, doesn't Divine Venerable want me to kill?" Ning Fuyi keenly detected her thoughts.

"Not exactly, just worried," Chu Qingqiu's eyes darkened.

"You're still worried about me turning into a demon," Ning Fuyi lowered her raised leg and sat side by side with her. "There are many things I haven't asked you about yet, like that reincarnation array, and your gardenia flower, and you..."

"I guess you also remember your past life. Can you tell me why I became a spider lily⁶, but I don't remember it?"

Chu Qingqiu's head turned slightly to one side, almost imperceptibly. She closed her eyes as if struggling to remember, then said softly: "Ning Fuyi, you're asking too much."

"These things, even Ning Changfeng⁷ doesn't know half of them."

"I'm sorry," Ning Fuyi quickly admitted her mistake. "If you don't want to say, pretend I never asked."

"It's fine," Chu Qingqiu exhaled, and the floral fragrance around her intensified. "The reason I could become a gardenia flower after death is because I was originally a gardenia flower."

"Do you remember what I told you about the last divine clans in the world?" she asked.

"Tang Huang, Hong Xi, Chi Du, Ting Feng⁸," Ning Fuyi replied. "I've heard the stories of Chi Du and Ting Feng, leaving only Tang Huang and Hong Xi."

"Tang Huang and Hong Xi were the most ancient divine clans. Over time, they fell in love, and because of love, they grew to hate. After severing their emotions and love, they became truly compassionate to heaven and earth. But that hatred for romantic love remained in their hearts."

"And I am a flower that grew at the base of the divine throne, listening daily to the true gods discuss scriptures and dao, absorbing divine nature until I developed consciousness. I should have cultivated into a spirit clan that absorbs the spiritual energy of heaven and earth. But later, when the gods fell, Tang Huang and Hong Xi's time was approaching but their mission was unfinished, so they infused their last trace of divine power into me, raising me as a demigod flower and instructing me to cultivate the path of no emotions, to protect all living beings in their place."

Ning Fuyi listened to her gentle narration as if hearing about an untouchable past, and couldn't help but open her eyes in surprise.

"No wonder, being of the spirit clan yet possessing such cultivation..." Ning Fuyi nodded slowly.

"Tang Huang and Hong Xi told me that when Pangu⁹ first created heaven and earth, the clear became heaven, the turbid became earth, and his body and hair became mountains, rivers, wind, clouds, rain, and snow. But there was one strand of evil qi that wasn't collected, which hid in the mortal world and was nourished by the resentment and evil of the six realms, eventually becoming an evil spirit called 'Mei'¹⁰."

"The evil spirit grew stronger day by day, having already developed divine consciousness and a body. It would eventually become a great calamity. Since I was born under divine light, I should naturally bear the responsibility of protecting the world. So I used divine power to cultivate human form and embarked on the path of seeking this evil spirit."

Ning Fuyi initially found this incredible, but upon reflection, it seemed reasonable. Chu Qingqiu had no family, her background was mysterious, she always went alone - nothing about her could be considered unusual.

So her gaze toward Chu Qingqiu held a few traces of hidden heartache.

She really was lonely.

"So you could be resurrected because of your demigod body?" Ning Fuyi asked carefully.

Chu Qingqiu's eyes lowered slightly: "More or less. When I took human form, three withered leaves remained by my ears, each representing a seed that could sprout when touching soil, bloom and resurrect."

"Three times, so now you've used one," Ning Fuyi moved closer to her and said softly, "So you originally wouldn't die. Even if I hadn't searched for your soul, you could have come back to life on your own?"

Chu Qingqiu looked at the misty sea of clouds and nodded twice.

"But I didn't expect that when I came back to life, perhaps a hundred years would have passed in the world. I never anticipated that in just thirty years, you would pull me back," Chu Qingqiu's eyes seemed to show some attachment to mortal days.

"But there aren't two more times," Chu Qingqiu smiled. "When the gods fell, I died with them, and used one seed then. I gave the last one to Qiu Yi."

"Ning Fuyi, I have no next life, and I no longer have the ability to save you," Chu Qingqiu turned to look at her, suddenly reaching out to tuck Ning Fuyi's messy bangs behind her ear, her gaze tender.

Ning Fuyi's heart grew more bitter. Chu Qingqiu had gradually stripped away her only branches and leaves, scattering them to all living beings and to her, until finally only a bare trunk remained, becoming an ordinary person.

"I won't need you to save me anymore. I'll protect you well, protect the people you want to protect," Ning Fuyi raised her hand to hold her soft hand in her palm, saying somewhat urgently, "I'll never make you angry again or act willfully."

"Just now at Wu Mountain, I was thinking that you must be tired from carrying such a burden for so long. I just want to love you well from now on and never make you cry again," Ning Fuyi held her cold hand tightly, warming it in her palm.

Hearing this, Chu Qingqiu actually laughed. When she smiled, she was extremely beautiful, her eyes bright and sparkling, even gentler than the spring breeze.

"You? Love me?" Chu Qingqiu seemed to find it ridiculous to use such words on herself, her thick lashes lowering as she looked at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes were blurred by the wind, but her gaze didn't waver an inch as she nodded gently.

Chu Qingqiu withdrew her smile and turned back, her free hand gripping Bai Lin's fur tightly. After struggling for a long time, she finally said in a low voice: "Yiyi, I'm a little cold."

Footnotes:

1. **Purple Mist Peak (紫霞峰)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence, a secluded mountain peak
2. **Yun Ke (云客)** - A contact who provides information, mentioned in previous chapters
3. **Yi Chan Sea (一阐海)** - A location within Penglai realm
4. **Xuanyuan Kingdom (轩辕国)** - An ancient kingdom that was home to snake demon clans
5. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Chu Qingqiu's white tiger companion
6. **Spider lily (彼岸花)** - Also known as red spider lily or higanbana, a flower associated with death and rebirth
7. **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's father, mentioned in earlier chapters
8. **Tang Huang, Hong Xi, Chi Du, Ting Feng (棠皇、鸿羲、赤都、听枫)** - The four remaining divine clans from ancient times
9. **Pangu (盘古)** - In Chinese mythology, the first being and creator of the universe
10. **Mei (昧)** - The evil spirit born from uncollected evil qi during creation